



PUJARA WAS NEVER A CREATURE OF THE AGE. WHEN CRICKET TILTED TOWARDS THE EPHEMERAL, HE OFFERED PERMANENCE. WHEN SPEED BECAME THE CURRENCY, HE TRADED IN SPAN



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deliveries, as if chiselling India's name into the ledger of champions stroke by stroke, leave by leave.

A few weeks after that triumph, I visited his home in Rajkot for a cover story. He welcomed us with warmth, unhurried and generous with his time, speaking at length about cricket and its demands. When it came to the photoshoot, our photographer insisted on multiple changes of outfit — four or five at least. Most players would have bristled; Pujara obliged with a smile, each time disappearing to change and returning without complaint. It

was a revealing glimpse of the man behind the batter: as patient in his living room as he had been against Pat Cummins and Josh Hazlewood, as unassuming in front of the camera as he was resolute in front of the stumps. **The stoicism that defined him at the crease was no performance; it was his nature.**

Yet, even as his reputation was built on defence, towards the twilight of his career he showed a different side. In Ranji Trophy games for Saurashtra, he could be seen